AI on AWS Hackathon — Judging Rubric Proposal

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Purpose and design principles

The winning POC should be one the customer would fund next quarter *and* one our architects would be willing to put their name on. The rubric weights Business Value 40%, Problem Solving 30% and Implementation Planning 30%, with two pass/fail gates on security and responsible AI.

The senior sales manager and the senior architect each get what they cannot compromise on:

- **Sales:** the customer's problem, measurable outcome and a credible path to a paid engagement dominate the score. A technically brilliant demo with no buyer does not win.
- **Architecture:** a POC cannot win on slides. It must run on AWS, be honest about what is mocked, and show a defensible path to production — security, cost and operability included.
- **Shared:** every criterion has written level descriptors, so judges score evidence, not charisma. Both perspectives sit on every judging panel.

Scoring model

Each team is scored out of 100 across nine criteria, after clearing two gates. Every criterion is rated 1–4, then multiplied by its weight factor.

Pillar	Criterion	Max points	Lead judge
Business Value (40)	1.1 Customer problem and stakeholder fit	12	Sales
Business Value (40)	1.2 Quantified impact and ROI	16	Sales

Pillar	Criterion	Max points	Lead judge
Business Value (40)	1.3 Path to adoption and commercial follow-on	12	Sales
Problem Solving (30)	2.1 Appropriateness of the AI approach	12	Architect
Problem Solving (30)	2.2 Working demo and evidence of quality	12	Architect
Problem Solving (30)	2.3 Creativity and use of AWS services	6	Joint
Implementation Planning (30)	3.1 Target architecture and production readiness	12	Architect
Implementation Planning (30)	3.2 Cost model and operability	9	Joint
Implementation Planning (30)	3.3 Delivery roadmap, risks and next steps	9	Sales

Rating scale (applies to every criterion)

Rating	Meaning	Points earned
4 — Exemplary	Customer-ready; could be shown to the buyer tomorrow	100% of max
3 — Strong	Solid, minor gaps a follow-up meeting would close	75% of max
2 — Developing	Right direction, material gaps or unsupported claims	40% of max
1 — Weak	Missing, generic or contradicted by the demo	10% of max

Gates (pass/fail, checked before scoring)

- **Security and data handling:** no customer data or secrets in code or prompts; least-privilege IAM; data stays in the agreed region. A fail disqualifies until fixed.

- **Responsible AI:** the team names its main failure mode (hallucination, bias, harmful output) and shows at least one guardrail, such as Amazon Bedrock Guardrails, grounding with citations, or human review.

Rule of evidence: any claim not shown in the demo, repo or architecture diagram caps that criterion at 2.

Pillar 1 — Business Value (40 points)

This pillar asks whether the customer would pay for this. Sales leads scoring here; the architect checks that the claimed value is something the demo can actually deliver.

Criterion	4 — Exemplary	3 — Strong	2 — Developing	1 — Weak
1.1 Customer problem and stakeholder fit (12)	Names the business owner, the user and the pain in the customer's own language; validated with customer input during the event	Clear problem and owner; validation is second-hand	Generic problem ("improve efficiency"); owner unclear	Solution looking for a problem
1.2 Quantified impact and ROI (16)	Baseline vs. target on 1–2 KPIs (e.g. handling time 12 → 4 min) with stated assumptions and a payback estimate	KPIs and targets given; assumptions partly stated	Benefits listed but not quantified	No measurable outcome

Criterion	4 — Exemplary	3 — Strong	2 — Developing	1 — Weak
1.3 Path to adoption and commercial follow-on (12)	Specific next engagement (pilot scope, users, duration, sponsor), change-management needs and how success is signed off	Next step and sponsor named; adoption risks touched on	Vague "next we would scale it"	No path beyond the demo

Questions judges should ask: Who signs the PO? What happens on Monday if this works? Which number moves, and by how much?

Pillar 2 — Problem Solving (30 points)

This pillar asks whether the team solved the stated problem, with the right amount of AI. The architect leads; sales checks the demo tells the customer's story rather than a tech tour.

Criterion	4 — Exemplary	3 — Strong	2 — Developing	1 — Weak
2.1 Appropriateness of the AI approach (12)	Justifies the choice (rules vs. ML vs. GenAI vs. agent) and model selection on accuracy, latency and cost; uses RAG or tools where grounding matters	Sound approach; trade-offs partly explained	AI used where simpler logic would do, or wrong pattern for the data	AI is decorative or unexplained

Criterion	4 — Exemplary	3 — Strong	2 — Developing	1 — Weak
2.2 Working demo and evidence of quality (12)	End-to-end flow runs live on AWS with realistic data; small evaluation set with results (e.g. 40 test questions, 88% correct); failure cases shown honestly	Live happy path works; quality judged informally	Partly scripted or mocked, and says so	Slides or video only, or breaks without explanation
2.3 Creativity and use of AWS services (6)	Novel angle on the problem; managed services chosen well (e.g. Amazon Bedrock, Bedrock Knowledge Bases or Agents, SageMaker, Lambda, Step Functions) without over-engineering	Sensible service choices; some novelty	Standard pattern, some odd choices	Services bolted on to tick boxes

Questions judges should ask: Why this model and not a cheaper one? Show me an answer it gets wrong. What is mocked?

Pillar 3 — Implementation Planning (30 points)

This pillar asks whether we could actually deliver this for the customer. It is where both views meet: the architect judges production readiness, sales judges whether the plan is sellable and sized to the customer's appetite.

Criterion	4 — Exemplary	3 — Strong	2 — Developing	1 — Weak
3.1 Target architecture and production readiness (12)	Diagram of POC vs. target state; covers identity, data flow, integration with customer systems, security controls and AWS Well-Architected trade-offs	Credible target state; one or two pillars thin	POC architecture only, no production view	No architecture shown
3.2 Cost model and operability (9)	Monthly run-cost estimate at pilot and full scale (tokens, compute, storage), cost levers named; monitoring, evaluation and model-update plan	Cost estimate at one scale; basic monitoring	Cost mentioned, not estimated	Cost and operations ignored
3.3 Delivery roadmap, risks and next steps (9)	Phased plan (e.g. 6-week pilot, 3-month production) with team, customer dependencies, top 3 risks with mitigations and go/no-go criteria	Phases and risks given; dependencies thin	Timeline with no risks or dependencies	No plan

Questions judges should ask: What does it cost per month at 10× the users? What do you need from the customer's IT team? What would make us stop?

Judging panel, process and tie-breakers

Each panel has three judges: one sales lead, one solutions architect, and one customer representative. The customer seat is advisory on Business Value and can be swapped for a delivery lead if the customer cannot attend.

1. **Calibration (30 min, before the event):** judges score one sample submission together and agree what a 2 vs. a 3 looks like.
2. **Gate check:** the architect confirms both gates from the repo and IAM setup before the pitch.
3. **Pitch and demo (10 min) plus Q&A (8 min):** the demo must be live; judges use the questions listed under each pillar.
4. **Independent scoring:** each judge scores every criterion alone, with a one-line evidence note per score.
5. **Reconciliation:** any criterion where judges differ by 2+ rating levels is discussed. The lead judge for that criterion (see the scoring table) makes the final call.
6. **Final score:** the average of the reconciled scores, out of 100.

Tie-breakers, in order: higher Business Value score; then higher criterion 2.2 (working demo); then the customer representative's preference.

Optional awards: Customer's Choice (customer votes only) and Best Architecture (architect panel only). They let each side recognise excellence the overall score might miss.

Required team submissions

Teams submit five items one hour before pitches. Each maps to the criteria it evidences, so judges know where to look.

Item	Format	Evidences
One-page value case: problem, owner, KPIs with baseline and target, ROI assumptions	1 page	1.1, 1.2, 1.3
Live demo running in the team's AWS account, plus a 2-minute backup recording	URL + video	2.2, 2.3
Repo with README stating what is real vs. mocked, and evaluation results	Git repo	Gates, 2.1, 2.2

Item	Format	Evidences
Architecture diagram: POC and target production state	1–2 slides	3.1
Cost estimate and 90-day delivery plan with top 3 risks	1 slide or sheet	3.2, 3.3

The backup recording is used only if AWS or network issues occur; a team relying on it is capped at 3 on criterion 2.2.

Where sales and architecture diverge, and how this proposal resolves it

The main tensions are about weight and evidence. Each one is settled by a specific mechanism, not a compromise weight.

Tension	Sales view	Architect view	Resolution in this rubric
Pillar weighting	Business value should be 50%+	Technical substance should be 50%+	40/30/30, but Pillar 3 is shared, so each side effectively controls about half the score
Polished pitch vs. working system	A compelling story wins deals	Slideware hides risk	Rule of evidence caps unproven claims at 2; live demo required
Ambition vs. honesty	Show the full vision	Show only what works	Teams pitch the vision but must label mocked parts; honesty is rewarded under 2.2
Security and responsible AI	Shouldn't slow a 48-hour event	Non-negotiable for a customer	Pass/fail gates, not points, so they can't be traded off against a nice UI
Cost	Customer cares about price later	Run-cost decides viability	Required estimate under 3.2, scored jointly

Open decisions for the organisers

- [ ] Confirm the 40/30/30 split, or move to 50/25/25 if this event is primarily a sales motion.
- [ ] Confirm whether a customer representative will judge, and whether their score counts or is advisory.
- [ ] Agree whether teams get sanitised customer data or synthetic data only.
- [ ] Set the AWS budget cap per team account and region.